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Experienced cyclist dies after hitting barrier on B&O Trail

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Written by
Lou Whitmire
News Journal

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BELLVILLE -- A 53-year-old man died Wednesday from injuries received in a bicycle crash Tuesday evening on the Richland B&O Trail.

Giuseppe Maino, a contractor at the 179th Airlift Wing of the Ohio National Guard base, died at 1:10 a.m., Richland County Coroner's Investigator Bob Ball said.

Bellville police Officer Burt Skeen said police responded to the bike trail shortly after 7 p.m. Tuesday, about 200 yards west of the bridge where Ogle and East streets meet. Maino, of Turin, Italy, was taken to MedCentral/Mansfield Hospital by Jefferson Township Fire Department rescue personnel. He underwent emergency surgery.



Maino

Maino was riding with a group of cyclists associated with Y-Not Cycling and Fitness in Lexington.

"He was to the rear of the group and only one gentleman was beside him. The other bicyclist was approaching the posts on the bike trail (which prevent cars from entering the trail or a park entrance) and he went ahead to make sure Giuseppe could pass either on the left or the right of the center pole. Mr. Maino impacted the pole," Skeen said.

These three posts were not at an intersection with any road, the police officer said.

"It was definitely a freak accident," Skeen said.

Ball said Maino's body is being held at the coroner's office until his family arrives here.



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Fellow bicyclist Jason Molyet, a News Journal photographer, was riding with the group when the crash occurred.



TB: Wooster at Madison



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"Giuseppe was one of the best cyclists I know and an even better human being," Molyet said. "He was a warm, enthusiastic man and I never saw him without a smile on his face. I will truly miss him and the passion he had for life."

Bicyclist Josh McKinney said the one thing anyone would tell you about Maino was that he was always happy to be there, happy to ride.

"He never had a bad day, was always happy, ready to go," McKinney said. "He came off as one of those people who would give you the shirt off his back. He's been riding with us for about a year. He had been riding in Italy and racing for about 30 years. He rode with us usually two or three times a week."

Maino had been a project engineer for Alenia Aeronautica since December 1981. He had been associated with the 179th since 2009. The company he worked for makes the C-27J airplane, a craft targeted on the federal government's budget cut list.

"He was instrumental in standing up this weapon system and its initial deployment where it is right now in Afghanistan," said Maj. Ken Kmetz of the 179th Airlift Wing.

"The first time I met him I liked him. He had an infectious laugh. He was a lot of fun. He enjoyed every day," cyclist Keith Elliott said. "He was a great bike handler. He was as comfortable at riding a bike as he was walking. He was one of those individuals you enjoyed being around."

Steve Yarman said a complete stranger could walk up to Maino and be comfortable.

"His smile was genuine. You felt totally at ease around him. He had that amazing personality trait about him," Yarman said. "His riding ability, he was head and shoulders above everyone else."

John Mumaw agreed Maino was an amazing rider.

"What an awful loss. It was a privilege to have him as part of our group. He was an exceptional rider," he said. "It was awful to see someone so skilled have such a random accident. I do hope we can change those barricades, that his death won't be in vain."

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